

Fiction Surges While Nonfiction Rewards Genuine Expertise

Prepared October 2026 · Sources are linked inline throughout

In 2025-2026 most readers read to relax and escape, and the money follows them. US adult fiction print units rose **5.7% in the first half of 2026** while adult nonfiction fell **5.8%**. The parallel indie ebook economy paid out **\$711.3M through Kindle Unlimited in 2025**, and nearly all of that went to series genre fiction. Nonfiction demand still exists, but it has narrowed to problems readers feel personally: overthinking and anxiety, relationships and hard conversations, midlife health, faith and meaning, and money. It now rewards books that offer a structured change led by a credible human, not information a chatbot gives away free. That distinction matters because the cheap end of nonfiction is flooded. About **77% of late-2025 releases in Amazon's "Success" self-help subcategory were likely AI-written**, yet human-written titles still earned about five times as many reviews. For a first-time author who prefers nonfiction, the best bet is a short, specific, workbook-style ebook for a named reader, on a problem you can speak to from lived experience or credentials. Price it at \$2.99-\$4.99 at launch, pair it with a paperback and audio edition, and launch it to an email list you start building now. If you choose fiction, the clearest openings are cozy fantasy (the best demand-to-competition ratio on Kindle), romance built around one specific trope (hockey/sports or dark dystopian), LitRPG and cozy mystery, and every one of them requires committing to a series. India is a growing secondary market but a print-heavy one: digital is about 6.5% of a ₹1.08 lakh crore market. Career, self-help, finance, spirituality and Indian-rooted fiction lead there, and you need KDP Select enrollment to earn the 70% royalty. Keep first-book expectations modest. The median self-published nonfiction book sells about **1,100 copies**.

Fiction gains 5.7% while nonfiction shrinks and audio takes the digital lead

Overall the US market is flat. Print units were **762.4 million in 2025 (+0.3%)** and slipped 0.3% in H1 2026 ([Publishers Weekly](#); [Publishers Weekly](#)). The flat total hides a sharp split. Adult fiction rose 1% in 2025 and **5.7% in H1 2026**, while adult nonfiction fell 1.5% and then **5.8%**, though nonfiction remains the largest print segment. In digital formats, publisher-reported audio has overtaken ebooks. AAP members' 2025 revenue was **\$2.5B from digital audio (+5.3%) against \$2.2B from ebooks (+3.2%)**, and in H1 2026 trade ebooks fell 3.0% to \$516.1M while trade digital audio grew 12.6% ([AAP](#); [AAP June 2026 StatShot](#)). Neither source sees most self-published activity. Circana counts print only, and AAP leaves out most KDP revenue. The indie ebook economy is still growing: the KDP Select fund paid self-publishers \$711.3M in 2025, up 11.2% ([The New Publishing Standard](#)), and the monthly fund was **\$66.0M in August 2026, paying \$0.00517 per page read**, the

highest rate in the tracker's 2024-2026 data ([Written Word Media](#)). The most plausible reading is that ebook reading is shifting toward KU and indie titles rather than shrinking. No public figure measures the whole US ebook market including self-published books, so that remains an inference.

The ebook reader is identifiable. Pew found **31% of US adults read an ebook in the past year**, rising to 41% of under-30s and 42% of college graduates, and women out-read men in ebooks 33% to 28% ([Pew Research Center](#)). Reading is concentrated: the median American finished just two books in 2025, and **the top 19% of readers account for 82% of books read** ([YouGov](#)). Those heavy readers are the people a self-published ebook actually reaches. In Written Word Media's 2026 survey of 3,589 active digital readers, a sample that skews toward fiction and bargain-hunting, the median respondent reads six books a month, most spend under \$5 per ebook, and 26% subscribe to Kindle Unlimited. Their motives are blunt: **86% read to relax, 83% to be entertained, 67% to escape, and only 30% for personal growth or learning** ([Written Word Media](#)). Half of readers in a separate Scribd survey re-read three or more books for comfort ([Scribd Inc.](#)). A nonfiction ebook is therefore selling to a smaller, problem-driven audience that has to be found deliberately. It cannot rely on the binge-reading crowd that keeps genre fiction going.

Supply is the other half of the picture. Self-published US titles reached about **3.5 million in 2025, up 38.7%** ([The New Publishing Standard](#)). A July 2026 study of 14,419 KDP titles found that books with substantial AI text reached about 20% of the catalog by Q2 2026 but took only 12.1% of launch-window sales. Released titles grew 38-fold while revenue grew only nine-fold, so the average book now earns less ([arXiv](#)). Platforms are pushing back. From September 21, 2026, KDP limits new titles to **two per format per week** ([ALLi](#)), and Kobo rejected 45% of 2025 self-published submissions, mostly as low-quality AI output ([The Next Web](#)). Neither limit will touch a debut author. Both slow the mass producers you would otherwise compete against.

Nonfiction readers now pay for transformation, not information

Category data shows where nonfiction demand is real. Self-help rose **14.7% in 2025**, but one title drove it: Mel Robbins' *The Let Them Theory* sold 2.8 million print copies and was the year's #1 book in any category. Religion grew 5.4% to about 67M units, while biography/memoir fell 7% and business/economics 3.9% ([Publishers Weekly](#)). Travel, health/fitness/medicine and general nonfiction all fell by double digits in the first nine months of 2025 ([Publishers Weekly](#)). In Q1 2026 **only two of 16 adult nonfiction subcategories grew: crafts/hobbies/games (+9.6%) and religion (+1.6%)**, while self-help fell 26.3% ([Publishers Weekly](#)). Bibles hit a 21-year high of 19M units, and Circana describes 2025 nonfiction as emphasizing "comfort and wellness" ([Publishers Weekly](#)). The UK shows the same pattern: personal development grew 13.5%, religion 10.5%, and philosophy 11.5% "driven by stoicism trends" while adult nonfiction overall fell 4.9% ([The Bookseller](#)). Part of self-help's 2026 slump is simply the comparison against Robbins' record year, so it overstates any loss of reader interest.

Bestseller lists show which topics sit underneath those categories. Mental health is durable. *The Body Keeps the Score*, a 2014 trauma book, was the most frequent NYT #1 nonfiction title of 2025 ([Wikipedia/NYT](#)), and *The Dialectical Behavior Therapy Skills Workbook* ranked #3 on the Kindle nonfiction bestseller list ([Amazon](#)). Overthinking has its own self-published proof. Joseph Nguyen's short book *Don't Believe Everything You Think* went viral on TikTok and has been translated into 40+ languages ([getAbstract](#)), and his follow-up, *The Overthinker's Guide to Making Decisions*, reached the hardcover list ([Publishers Weekly](#)). Midlife women's health broke out when *How to Menopause* debuted at #5 with 14,958 copies in one week ([Publishers Weekly](#)). Search interest in "perimenopause book" is up 185% but now tagged "peaked" ([Exploding Topics](#)), which points to narrower angles rather than general guides. Longevity (*Heal Your Cells* debuted at #3 in September 2026) and GLP-1 companion books such as *Losing the Weight Loss Meds: A 10-Week Playbook* are still young niches ([Publishers Weekly](#); [Simon & Schuster India](#)). Communication books keep charting: *The Next Conversation* had sold 72,143 copies by April 2025, and Priya Parker's *The Art of Fighting* charted in 2026. Men and masculinity is an emerging thread, with Scott Galloway's *Notes on Being a Man* at 93,054 units ([Publishers Weekly](#); [Publishers Weekly](#)). Rounding out the evergreen clusters are parenting in the age of screens (*Dopamine Kids*, an Amazon editors' pick of 2026), money psychology (Morgan Housel's *The Art of Spending Money*, an NYT #1) and true crime, which Circana flags as a 2026 growth subject ([Amazon](#); [Penguin Random House](#); [Circana](#)). Most of these hits came from authors who already had a podcast, TikTok or TV platform. A newcomer can borrow the topics but should not expect the numbers.

Format determines which of these topics can work as an ebook. UK NielsenIQ data show **self-help/popular psychology is the top nonfiction genre in both ebooks and audiobooks**, that computing/IT has the highest ebook share of any nonfiction genre, and that travel, art/photography and craft remain more than 90% print. Buyers aged 25-44 make 60% of digital self-help purchases ([NielsenIQ](#)). The fastest-growing nonfiction segments, crafts, puzzles, coloring, journals and cookbooks, are therefore mostly print growth and a poor fit for a Kindle-first debut. Circana's 2026 outlook backs this up with its call for "screen-free categories" ([Circana](#)).

The AI squeeze is the biggest change for nonfiction. Originality.ai judged **77% of 844 books** released in Amazon's "Success" self-help subcategory between August and November 2025 likely AI-written. Those books leaned on words like "Blueprint," "Code," "Wealth" and "Secrets." Human-written books averaged **about 129 reviews against 26** and ran 187 pages against 157 ([Originality.ai](#)). In herbal remedies, 82% of 2025 titles were likely AI-written, some with dangerous foraging advice ([Originality.ai](#)). An analysis of about 77,000 AI-written books ranked self-help (10.8%), health and fitness (9.6%) and business (7.2%) as the most targeted categories ([PPC Land](#)). Chatbots also compete on the demand side. **26% of US adults, and 46% of under-30s, have used ChatGPT to learn something new** ([Pew Research Center](#)). Tim Ferriss reports his BookScan print sales fell 46% in 2025 and are down 57% in 2026. He argues that prescriptive "information" nonfiction is collapsing into chatbots while story-driven and transformation-driven nonfiction holds up ([Tim Ferriss](#)). That is one author's data and his own interpretation, but it fits the category numbers. Readers

still value human work: 43% of business/self-help readers would feel "much less fulfilled" on learning a book was AI-written ([YouGov](#)). For "self" genres, subject matter and reviews or recommendations drive purchases more than covers do ([NielsenIQ](#)).

The formats that still win are the ones a chatbot struggles to replace: workbooks and skills manuals (the DBT workbook), how-to books for a life stage (*How to Menopause*), guides written for a named audience (*The Overthinker's Guide*, *The ADHD Field Guide for Adults*), daily formats (Jim Kwik's *Limitless Daily: 366 Keys*), playbooks with a fixed time frame, and one memorable branded idea (Let Them). Short books also hold up. Nguyen's breakout was a short self-published book, and *If Anyone Builds It, Everyone Dies* was deliberately written at about 60,000 words ([Publishers Weekly](#); [BookNet Canada](#); [GreaterWrong](#)). Neurodivergence shows narrower signals as well. In Canada, autism psychology subjects grew 30% and ADHD rose 6% in Q4 2025, even as total neurodiversity nonfiction dipped slightly ([BookNet Canada](#)).

Fiction's momentum has moved from romantasy to cozy, dark and game-like niches

Romance is still the largest fiction category, but its boom has peaked. Print romance was **up 24% year-to-date in June 2025**, led by triple-digit growth in romantasy and sports romance ([Circana](#)). It finished the year only **+3.9% at about 44M units**, and fantasy fell 8.7% even though *Onyx Storm* was the year's top novel. Growth moved to science fiction (+22.1%) and graphic novels (+9.2%) ([Publishers Weekly](#)), then to graphic novels again (+36.2% in H1 2026) and to manga (+45% in Q1 2026) ([Publishers Weekly](#); [Circana](#)). Horror grew 7% in the first nine months of 2025 ([Publishers Weekly](#)), and psychological thrillers were up 29% at mid-2025 ([Circana](#)). Forecasts for romantasy disagree. Everand predicts "romantasy fatigue" ([People via Yahoo](#)), while BookTok creators see "no sign of stopping," name paranormal romantasy as the sub-trend to watch, and expect epic fantasy and sci-fi to gain ([The Bookseller](#)). The likeliest outcome is a plateau with a temporary spike: Sarah J. Maas's next two ACOTAR books arrive **October 27, 2026 and January 12, 2027** ([Scary Mommy](#)).

Kindle data matters more for an indie author, and it shows clear gaps between supply and demand. K-lytics' summer 2026 analysis gives **cozy fantasy the highest sales-to-competition ratio in fantasy (23.1)**. It has only about 2,576 competing titles, and its top-20 books average about 60 sales a day each. LitRPG scores 14.8 and K-lytics calls it the "most structurally undersupplied success story." Fantasy-romantic hybrids (10.2) and gaslamp (6.2) follow. Within Kindle sci-fi, **dystopian (+45%), sci-fi adventure (+49%) and LGBTQ+ sci-fi (+48%)** are rising. Sci-fi romance has fallen 56%, colonization 96%, military space marine 84%, and myths-and-legends fantasy 90% ([Author Media/K-lytics](#)). Traditional print and indie Kindle disagree here. The 22% print sci-fi boom comes from Andy Weir, Suzanne Collins and film tie-ins, and it does not justify entering indie sci-fi romance. LitRPG

is also going mainstream: Tor is publishing Will Wight's *Overworld*, Harper Voyager is publishing the web serial *The Wandering Inn*, and *Dungeon Crawler Carl* is in development at Peacock ([Reactor](#)).

Romance subtypes with fresh proof of demand are now feeding traditional deals. HBO's *Heated Rivalry* adaptation lifted the book's unit sales almost 1,000% and the Game Changers series almost 4,000%, to 206,000 copies in six weeks ([Publishers Weekly](#)). That points to queer and hockey romance. In May 2026, PW listed self-published authors who moved to traditional publishers in hockey romance, omegaverse/polyamory, monster rom-com, cozy romantasy, dark romance and dark academia. One editor said indie authors "can push the envelope faster and more aggressively" ([Publishers Weekly](#)). The clearest indie template is H.M. Wolfe's *Daggermouth*, a dark dystopian romance self-published in December 2025. It logged **22.3 million KU page reads** within about two months and then sold in a "major seven-figure" US auction ([Pan Macmillan](#)). Breakouts also happen outside genre. Allen Levi's self-published, kindness-themed *Theo of Golden* was the #1 US print book of H1 2026 with 1.2M units ([Wikipedia](#); [Publishers Weekly](#)). That is an inspiring outlier, not a base rate.

The saturated corners are just as clear. **62% of September 2025 paranormal romance releases were judged likely AI junk**. Christmas romance has about 32,000 titles, and the #1,000 title sells about four copies a day ([Author Media/K-lytics](#)). In the genres most exposed to AI (crime/suspense romance, sci-fi/dystopian, mystery/thriller), human-written books' share of top-25 rank slots fell from about 88% to 63% ([arXiv](#)). Even so, romance remains where indie authors earn the most. Romance writers are about 21% of Written Word Media's survey respondents but **44% of authors earning \$10,000+ a month**. Paranormal romance appears among top earners at about 2.5 times its expected share, and cozy mystery holds 6-9% of every income bracket above \$500 a month ([Written Word Media](#)). Cozy mystery is the steady earner in that data, not the breakout.

Every fiction niche comes with the same requirement: write a series, and write it quickly. On Kindle, **89% of fantasy bestsellers are in series**, averaging 537 pages. Indie fantasy prices sit at \$4.99-\$6.99, and \$7.99-\$8.99 is a "dead zone." Sci-fi's sweet spot is \$5.99. **78 of the top 100 fantasy titles are in KU and take 83% of royalties** ([Author Media/K-lytics](#)), and 84% of Christmas romance royalties come through KU ([Author Media/K-lytics](#)). Authors earning \$5,000-\$20,000 a month typically release three to four books a year ([Written Word Media](#)). Since Kindle Vella closed, serial fiction runs on other platforms. LitRPG follows a Royal Road → Patreon → KU → audio pipeline ([Wikipedia](#)), and Spotify now commissions 10,000-20,000-word original short-form audiobooks in romance, mystery/thriller and SFF from indie authors, who keep their print and ebook rights ([Publishers Marketplace](#)).

A self-published nonfiction book sells a median of 1,100 copies, and platform decides the outliers

The base rates are sobering and are worth knowing up front. In a 2023 survey of nonfiction authors, self-published books sold a **median of 1,100 copies**. Only 8% passed 10,000 copies and none passed 50,000, against a median of 7,100 copies for traditionally published books

(Bernoff). Across indie authors, **44% earn \$100 a month or less, and about 80% of authors with one to three books earn under \$100 a month** (Written Word Media). Only 6% of that survey's respondents write nonfiction, so its patterns lean toward fiction.

Business-book authors in a 2024 study earned a median of \$5,500 directly from their book against \$18,200 in total revenue once speaking and consulting were counted (The Tilt). For many nonfiction authors the book is a credibility engine first and a revenue source second.

The measurable difference-makers are an audience and word of mouth. Authors with an email list earn a **median of \$300 a month against \$15** for those without one (Written Word Media). Heavy readers discover books through Amazon (68%) and email newsletters (64%), and fewer than 1% use AI tools (Written Word Media). Among general readers, recommendations from people they know beat algorithms (Scribd Inc.). The documented indie nonfiction successes all started from an existing audience. Paul Millerd's *The Pathless Path* reached 50,000 sales and about \$200,000 in profit. A single YouTube recommendation helped drive 3,402 sales in one month, audio grew to about a quarter of sales, and **cutting the ebook from \$9.99 to \$4.99-\$7.99 raised both units and profit** (Pathless Path). David Kadavy shows the reverse. His 2025 book revenue fell 50% after a year without a new release, his Meta ads lost effectiveness, and he left KU after it underperformed (Kadavy). Production quality also tracks with income. Most authors earning \$5,000+ a month spend \$250 or more on covers, while over half of those under \$100 a month spend \$0-\$100 (Written Word Media).

AI has a narrow, safe role in the writing process. KDP requires you to disclose **AI-generated** text, images or translations, even if you edit them heavily afterwards. **AI-assisted** work, where you wrote it and AI edited or error-checked it, needs no disclosure (KDP Content Guidelines). Readers punish more than policy does. 61% of Americans feel less fulfilled on learning a book was AI-written (YouGov). More than 80% of heavy readers prefer human audiobook narration (Written Word Media), and AI narration was just **0.03% of 2025 audiobook revenue**, even as US audiobook sales rose 9% to \$2.43B (Audio Publishers Association via Infodocket). Audio is where the growth is: Spotify reports audiobook listening hours up 60% year over year (Spotify), and Libby audiobook loans grew 13% against 3% for ebooks (OverDrive via Infodocket). An ebook-only plan leaves the fastest-growing format unused.

India offers growth, but mostly in print, vernacular apps and low price points

India's book market was about **₹1.08 lakh crore in 2024-25**, projected to reach ₹2 lakh crore by 2030-31. Digital publishing is only about ₹7,048 crore, roughly 6.5% of the total, and the growth is driven by education and Indian-language content (NielsenIQ BookData/FIP via India CSR). Amazon India reported double-digit growth in literary fiction, self-help, business and children's books. **Tier 2 cities grew at twice the metro rate**, Malayalam and Tamil demand doubled, government exam prep rose 30%+, and engineering and law materials rose 50%+ (Amazon India). Penguin Random House India says adult fiction is the

fastest-growing trade segment, with its own fiction share rising from 20% to 27% between 2022 and 2024. Its campaigns group fiction into thrillers ("Love, Lies, Laash"), mythology retellings ("India's Mythoverse") and "Desi Romance," and it names self-improvement, entrepreneurship, personal finance, spirituality, history and leadership as the sought-after nonfiction ([Penguin Random House India](#)). Those nonfiction lanes overlap closely with the US clusters above, which makes India a natural add-on for a career, finance or spirituality ebook.

Digital reading in India looks different from Kindle reading in the US. Young readers favor mobile, serialized and vernacular formats. Pratilipi reports 12M+ monthly readers across 12 languages (a secondary profile, so indicative only) ([Think Tank](#)). In a Pocket FM survey of 20,538 people, 84% of listeners were 18-35, 53% listened in Hindi, and 75% preferred paying per episode over a subscription ([Pocket FM via MediaInfoline](#)). Kindle Unlimited launched in India at ₹199 a month (2016 data), which anchors low price expectations, and Kindle supports Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Gujarati and Malayalam ebooks ([The Bookseller](#)). Two mechanics matter most. Amazon.in's 70% royalty band runs from ₹99 to ₹599 ([KDP Help](#)), and **India sales earn the 70% rate only when the book is enrolled in KDP Select**; otherwise they earn 35% ([KDP Help](#); [Reedsy](#)). A third-party KDP India guide also notes that KDP has no Indian print centre, so KDP paperbacks reach Indian buyers as slow, expensive imports ([KDPIndia.com](#)). No public 2025-26 data on Kindle India sales, top titles or KU subscribers was found, so treat India as a secondary channel to test, not a primary revenue plan.

Conclusions

The usual question for first-time authors, "what's hot," has a less exciting but more useful answer in 2026. The hottest nonfiction topics are crowded at the top by platform-backed authors with publisher budgets and at the bottom by AI volume. The opening for an unknown author lies where three things meet: a durable demand cluster (emotional skills, relationships, faith and meaning, money, midlife health), a reader narrow enough to name, and something only you can supply, such as lived experience, credentials, original cases or a program you have run. The shift from information to transformation is the most consequential change in the data. Chatbots have absorbed the "10 steps to X" book, so value has moved to voice, structure and accountability, and the review gap between human and AI books shows readers can still tell them apart. Combined with Amazon's new upload caps, that could make 2027 friendlier to careful human authors than 2024-25 were. That is a reasoned bet, not yet a measured trend.

Fiction and nonfiction come with different constraints, and the right choice depends on which constraint you can meet. Fiction offers the larger market, KU's built-in discovery and clearer gaps (cozy fantasy, LitRPG), but it demands a series and steady output. Nonfiction allows a single-book path, but only with a discovery channel you build yourself. Much of the evidence is also incomplete. No public source splits ebook-only sales by genre, KU data on

nonfiction is thin, and India's Kindle numbers are not published. Your own keyword research on Amazon, done before you write, is therefore worth more than any trend report, this one included.

Recommendations: what to write, how to price it, and what to do first

Five nonfiction directions ranked for a debut ebook

The ranking weighs demand evidence, fit with the ebook format, how heavily AI titles crowd the category, and how achievable it is for an author without a platform. Biography and memoir are excluded as you requested; they are also declining (-7% in 2025). Each direction works only if you have real experience or credentials to bring to it. Pick the highest-ranked one where that is true.

Rank	Direction and example angles	Why demand supports it	Competition reality	Recommended format and angle
1	Emotional and mental skills for a named reader: overthinking, anxiety, burnout, emotional regulation, adults with late-diagnosed ADHD	Self-help/pop psych is the #1 nonfiction genre in ebook and audio; DBT workbook in Kindle top 3; self-published Nguyen breakout; durable backlist demand	The most AI-flooded category (77% of "Success" titles), but human books earn ~5x the reviews; avoid "success/wealth/mindset blueprint" framing	30-50k-word workbook or 30-day program with exercises and a printable PDF; one branded core idea; personal story woven in; add audio early
2	Communication and relationships: difficult conversations, conflict at home or work, dating confidence, modern masculinity	<i>The Next Conversation</i> , <i>The Art of Fighting</i> , <i>Notes on Being a Man</i> on 2025-26 lists; TikTok revives dating classics; UK self-help ranks high with men under 45 (NielsenIQ)	Many hits are creator-driven; less documented AI saturation than "success" self-help	Scripts and phrasebook format ("what to say when..."), aimed at one relationship or one life stage
3	Faith, spirituality and practical philosophy: devotionals, stoic daily practice, meaning in midlife	Religion was one of only two growing US nonfiction subcategories in Q1 2026; Bibles at a 21-year high; UK religion +10.5%, philosophy +11.5%; spirituality is sought after in India	Smaller, values-driven communities; BookBub's Christian Nonfiction list reaches 410k+ subscribers (BookBub)	Daily or 52-week format (the <i>Limitless Daily</i> model) for a specific tradition or situation
4	Money and career for a defined audience: spending psychology, first-job finances, retirement income, exam/career prep (India)	Housel's NYT #1; <i>The Forever Paycheck</i> debuted at #11 in Sept 2026 (Publishers Weekly); Amazon India exam prep +30%; personal finance and entrepreneurship sought after in India	Business/economics -3.9% in the US; generic "wealth" and "AI side hustle" titles look like AI output to readers	Region-specific guide (US or India rules, tax, products), where a chatbot's generic answer falls short; specialized books can now be priced up to \$12.99 at 70%

Rank	Direction and example angles	Why demand supports it	Competition reality	Recommended format and angle
5	Midlife health in the GLP-1 era (conditional on credentials): perimenopause symptom plans, strength and protein after 40, coming off GLP-1s	<i>How to Menopause</i> debuted at #5; <i>Heal Your Cells</i> at #3; a growing shelf of GLP-1 companion titles from major publishers	Search interest "peaked"; health/fitness is the #2 AI category; print health fell double digits; safety risk without expertise	Time-boxed playbook with trackers ("10-week..."), clearly credentialed author bio, evidence-cited

Story-driven nonfiction is a sixth option if you love research. Regional or historical **true crime** tops Kindle nonfiction snapshots, appears in Circana's 2026 growth list and has a 580k+ subscriber BookBub list ([BookBub](#)), but it requires records access and narrative skill. Avoid generic success and wealth books, herbal remedies, ChatGPT and side-hustle guides, cookbooks, crafts, puzzle books and travel guides (all print-dominant or AI-saturated), and politics (platform-driven).

Fiction niches worth considering

Niche	Why now	Watch-outs	What you must commit to
Cozy fantasy, including cozy romantasy	Best fantasy sales-to-competition ratio on Kindle (23.1); matches readers' comfort and escape motives; cozy romantasy has an indie-to-traditional deal	Smaller per-title volume (~60/day for top-20 titles); needs a distinct setting and voice	A 3+ book series; \$4.99-\$6.99; KU
Romance with one specific trope: hockey/sports (including queer), or dark dystopian romance	Biggest indie earnings (romance is 44% of \$10K+/month authors); <i>Heated Rivalry</i> surge; <i>Daggermouth's</i> 22.3M KU page reads	Most competitive and AI-exposed space; generic tropes down; dark content needs careful content notes	Trope-precise covers and blurbs; release every 3-4 months; KU
LitRPG / progression fantasy	"Most structurally undersupplied" (ratio 14.8); traditional publishers and TV adaptations are arriving	Readers expect very long books and series; best for writers who know games	Serialize on Royal Road first, then KU and audio
Cozy mystery	Holds 6-9% of every indie income bracket above \$500/month; loyal series readers	No hard growth data; it is a steady earner, not a breakout genre	A long series with a recurring sleuth and setting

Skip generic dragon-academy and fae-court romantasy, indie sci-fi romance (-56%), military space marine (-84%), myths-and-legends fantasy (-90%), Christmas romance (#1,000 sells ~4/day), and paranormal/shifter romance as a newcomer (62% of recent releases likely AI junk). If you write romantasy or cozy romantasy, the January 12, 2027 Maas release is a realistic timing hook. October 27, 2026 is too close for a debut.

Pricing and distribution playbook

Decision	Recommendation	Basis
Nonfiction ebook price	Launch at \$2.99-\$4.99, then move to \$4.99-\$6.99 once you have 20+ reviews; test \$9.99-\$12.99 only for specialized professional books	The 70% band is now \$2.99-\$12.99 on Amazon.com from July 7, 2026 (Authors Guild); most heavy readers pay under \$5; Millerd's price cut raised profit
Fiction ebook price	\$4.99-\$6.99 for fantasy (avoid \$7.99-\$8.99); use promos on book 1; ~\$3.99-\$5.99 for shorter romance	K-lytics price lanes (Author Media)
File size	Keep the ebook lean and compress images; deliver heavy worksheets as a separate PDF	Amazon.com deducts \$0.15/MB at 70% (KDP Help); a \$4.99, 1MB ebook nets ~\$3.39
KDP Select vs wide	Fiction: Select (KU drives 80%+ of fantasy and seasonal romance royalties). Nonfiction: enroll for one 90-day term to use promotions and learn, then go wide if page reads are weak	A fully read 200-page nonfiction book earns about \$1 in KU against ~\$3.39 per \$4.99 sale (Written Word Media); Kadavy left KU; Kindlepreneur suggests KU while learning (Kindlepreneur)
Paperback	Always publish one for nonfiction, priced at \$9.99 or more	Royalty drops to 50% below \$9.99 since June 2025 (KDP Help); nonfiction print earns more per copy and suits workbooks and gifts
Audio	Plan it from the start. Use Spotify's free AI tool (up to 5 titles) as a low-cost nonfiction test; prefer human narration for fiction or once demand is proven	Free ElevenLabs-powered production for US indies (ALLi); audio was ~25% of Millerd's sales; listeners strongly prefer human voices
Libraries	Send the ebook to libraries through Draft2Digital's "library channels only" option, even while in KU	KDP Select library exception since Sept 2025; D2D library royalties up ~24% (Draft2Digital)
Direct sales	Sell a PDF workbook bundle and give away a lead magnet through BookFunnel or Payhip	30% of indies sell direct and about half of \$10K+/month earners do (Written Word Media)
India	Enroll in KDP Select (required for 70% on Amazon.in); price at the low end of the ₹99-₹599 band; use India-specific examples; consider a Hindi edition once the English one proves itself	KDP India terms; KU India sets low price anchors; Hindi is 53% of Pocket FM listening. Kindle Translate covers only English → Spanish and German → English (Slator), so a Hindi edition needs a human translator

Next steps for the next six months

When	Action	You are done when
Weeks 1-2	From the shortlist, choose two or three directions where you have real experience or credentials, and write a one-line promise for each: "For [named reader] who [problem], this book delivers [result] in [time frame]."	You have 2-3 promises you could defend in a podcast interview
Weeks 2-3	Check each promise on Amazon. For 5-10 buyer keywords, record the top 10-15 results, convert their Best Seller Ranks with the free Kindlepreneur calculator , and count how many books have 100+ reviews and were published in the last two years. Favor keywords where page-one books sit under ~100,000 BSR ("consistent movement") but several have fewer than 100 reviews. That is a low-barrier pattern cited by Vappingo ; treat it as a rule of thumb, not an Amazon figure. Read the 1-3-star reviews to find what readers felt was missing.	One topic is chosen, with a list of competitor gaps
Weeks 3-4	Start an email list with a free worksheet or sample chapter, and choose one channel (short video, Substack or a community you already belong to) to post about the problem every week	The list exists and your first 50-100 subscribers are signed up

When	Action	You are done when
Months 2-3	Draft 30,000-50,000 words in your own voice, structured as a program with exercises. Use AI only for brainstorming, outlining and editing (no disclosure needed). Recruit beta readers from your list.	A complete draft and feedback from at least 10 readers
Month 4	Hire a professional editor and cover designer (budget \$250+ for the cover). Build a lean ebook, a paperback priced at \$9.99 or more, and a PDF workbook. Write a plain-language description that avoids AI-style words like "Blueprint" and "Secrets."	Files are uploaded and advance review copies are out
Month 5	Launch in KDP Select at \$2.99, rise to \$4.99 after reviews accumulate, email your list, run a small Amazon Ads test, and enable library distribution	20+ reviews in the first month
Month 6 onward	Add audio, review your 90-day KU and sales data to decide whether to stay in Select or go wide, set your India price, and start book two on a neighboring problem for the same reader	A second book is outlined; the series begins

If you choose fiction instead, draft books one to three of a series before launching and then release every three to four months. For LitRPG, serialize on Royal Road while you draft.